April 22 terror attack in Pahalgam and the retaliatory Operation Sindoor. The hyper-nationalist climate had already seen *Abir Gulaal*, starring Pakistani actor Fawad Khan with Vaani Kapoor, cancel its release in India in May. But Diljit, one of India's most popular cultural icons, sharing screen space with a Pakistani actress, even if the movie was shot much before the Pahalgam attack, irked a section of the film fraternity—the voluble social media commentariat.

After the Uri (2016) and Pulwama (2019) terror attacks, Bollywood effectively imposed a blanket ban on collaborations with Pakistani artists. Thus, the Federation of Western India Cine Employees (FWICE) sent off letters to T-Series, filmmaker Imtiaz Ali et al, urging them to reconsider ongoing projects with Diljit. Its chief advisor Ashoke Pandit even warned of a "non-cooperation call" if the appeal was ignored—meaning daily-wage workers and technicians would refuse to report to Diljit's film sets. "For us, the nation comes first. Nothing is bigger," Pandit told INDIA TODAY, lambasting Diljit for being "arrogant" and ignoring Hania's now-deleted Instagram story that had criticised India's air strikes. Punjabi singers also joined the chorus. Mika Singh labelled Diljit a "fake singer" while B Praak made a cryptic post about artists who "sell their conscience".

THE SURPRISE DEFENCE

As hashtags like #BoycottDiljit began trending, the biggest twist in the saga came when the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—known for its hardline stance after Uri and Pulwama—decided to back the actor. The party's Punjab unit held a press conference in Chandigarh to defend Diljit. "You can't conflate a film made in a different context with current geopolitics," said party leader and Punjabi actor Hobby Dhaliwal. Even BJP national spokesperson R.P. Singh rallied behind Diljit. "Diljit is a global ambassador of Indian culture," he said. "He can't be held hostage to the actions or words of a co-star." Support also came from Sikh leaders across party lines—AAP's Rajya Sabha MP Vikramjit Singh Sahney, Congress veteran Partap Singh Bajwa and Akali Dal leader Manjit Singh GK. But it was the BJP's defence that stood out for its calibrated contrast to the hardliners.



"For us, the nation comes first. Nothing is bigger. When a country is responsible for massacre after massacre, you cannot work with those people"

ASHOKE PANDIT
Chief Advisor, Federation of Western India Cine Employees



"Diljit is a global ambassador of Indian culture. You can't hold him hostage to the actions or words of a co-star, especially when the context predates recent hostilities"

R.P. SINGH
National Spokesperson, BJP

That's perhaps because Diljit is no ordinary celebrity. A Coachella performer with Billboard hits and one of the few Punjabi entertainers with truly global appeal, he continues to maintain deep emotional ties to his roots. "*Main Hoon Punjab*" (I am Punjab)—a resonant slogan from his blockbuster 2024 *Dil-Luminati* tour—captured that connection perfectly. For the BJP, still trying to regain its footing in Punjab after the 2020–21 farmers' protest, alienating someone like him would be politically shortsighted. In fact, in the first week of January, amid media glare, Diljit had met Prime Minister Narendra Modi at his residence. For the party, it was a way to preserve support among Punjab's moderate Sikhs and counter any radical narratives amplified by Pakistan-backed overseas groups.

THE INCONVENIENT TRUTH

Despite backing from the ruling party, the inconvenient truth is that Diljit's fans in India may have to rely on piracy to watch *Sardaar Ji 3*, with OTT platforms likely to steer clear of the film for fear of hyper-nationalist backlash. Amid this atmosphere of self-censorship, the bigger question now is whether Diljit's future projects will be quietly cancelled at home.

So far, T-Series is standing firm and sticking with him for its highly-anticipated *Border 2*. "We've already shot 50 per cent of the film. The announcement of his casting was made almost nine months ago. The news of his replacement is not true," a company source says. Imtiaz Ali, who worked with Diljit on *Amar Singh Chamkila* and is reuniting with him for a romantic drama, referred to him as "the son of the soil" during a recent event. As for Diljit, he remains unfazed. Team Dosanjh, an official Instagram handle, proudly declared *Sardaar Ji 3* to be "one Punjabi film standing tall among all the Hollywood films". The film may have conquered global charts, but in India, it's caught between borders. ■